Understanding Diabetes

What is Diabetes?

Diabetes is a condition that develops when your blood glucose (blood sugar) levels are too high.

The Role of Insulin

Insulin is a hormone made by the pancreas that works like a key, unlocking the doors to the body's cells so that glucose can move from the blood into cells for energy.

In diabetes, this process does not work correctly, causing glucose to stay in the blood.

Types of Diabetes

In **Type 1 diabetes**, the pancreas does not produce a sufficient amount insulin.

In **Type 2 diabetes** the pancreas produces insulin but it cannot be used by the body effectively.

About SACH

South Asian Community Health (SACH) is an organization dedicated to enhancing patient education and combating health disparities through project-based initiatives designed to uplift the health and well-being of the South Asian community.

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The SACH of Diabetes

Preventative Measures

The ADA suggests incorporating a **diet of high quality foods** such as non-starchy vegetables, lean meats, low-fat dairy products, and fiber-rich foods.

South Asians are recommended to begin regular diabetes screenings at a lower **BMI of 23,** compared to the standard threshold of 25 for the general population (ADA).

Incorporating at least 150 minutes of moderate-level intensity **exercise each week** can help manage blood sugar (CDC).

Talk to your doctor about concerns regarding your pre-disposed risk to diabetes and the implications it can have on your health.

Risk Factors

The following are general risk factors of diabetes, outlined by the CDC:

- Family history (Type 1 & 2 diabetes)
- Overweight or obese (Type 2)
- Lack of physical activity (Type 2)

Disparities In Diagnosis

South Asians are at a higher risk of developing diabetes at a **younger age** compared to other ethnicities. Moreover, they can develop diabetes at **lower BMI levels**, meaning the condition can arise even in individuals who are not overweight.

The risk thresholds for diabetes in South Asian patients differ from those of the general population, highlighting the need for **culturally tailored diabetes care** and modified screening guidelines to be implemented by healthcare providers.

Diabetes in South Asians is linked to **higher mortality** rates, as it can exacerbate preexisting cardiovascular risk factors.

Why South Asians?

Biological Factors

Research suggests that South Asians have a genetic predisposition to diabetes, characterized by inherently **lower insulin production** and **increased insulin resistance**.

Lifestyle Factors

The traditional **South Asian diet** often involves consuming foods rich in carbohydrates and saturated fats. These foods can cause spikes in blood glucose levels and increase insulin resistance over time.

Low physical activity is common among South Asian populations, further increasing their risk of developing diabetes.

Symptoms (CDC)

- frequent urination
- increased thirst / dehydration
- fatigue
- weight loss
- blurry vision
- frequent infections
- slow healing